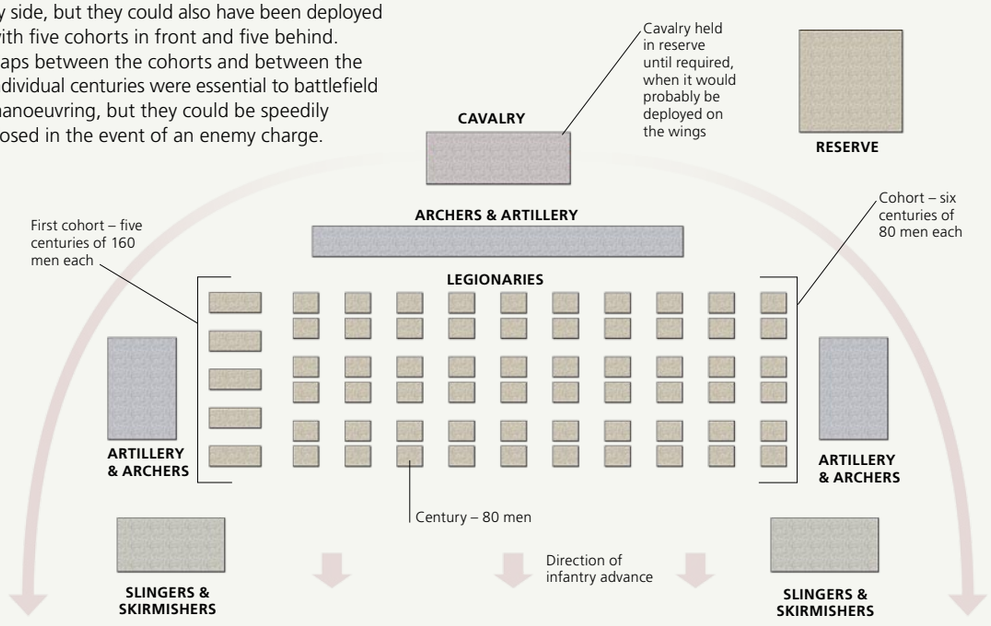
ROMAN BATTLEFIELD TACTICS

Roman battle tactics obviously changed radically over time and depended on whether they were fighting fellow Romans or "barbarians". The Romans would also have to adapt their battle formations to the terrain and in order to counter forces employing large numbers of cavalry or chariots. The deployment of troops shown below is one that might have been adopted by a legion – along with its cavalry and assorted auxiliary troops – to confront a "barbarian" enemy fighting largely on foot, such as the Britons in the 1st century CE. Roman infantry drew up on the battlefield in close order, with the most reliable troops in the front lines. The first century of each cohort, the one with the best troops, was placed in front of the others with the veterans at the rear.

When the moment came for battle to be joined – usually after a prolonged exchange of arrows, slingshots, and artillery – the cohorts advanced in silence at a slow and steady pace to meet the warriors charging towards them. It was at this point that the discipline of the legionary was put most severely to the test, for there had to be no wavering as the enemy came ever closer. Then the order was given to charge. The previously silent legionaries would raise a spine-chilling shout and hurl their javelins into the mass of the enemy, then surge forward to make contact, shoving with their shields and stabbing with their short swords.

A legion in order of battle

Here the cohorts of a legion are lined up side by side, but they could also have been deployed with five cohorts in front and five behind. Gaps between the cohorts and between the individual centuries were essential to battlefield manoeuvring, but they could be speedily closed in the event of an enemy charge.



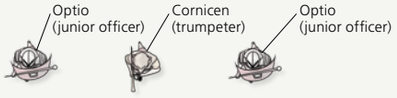
Order of battle

Depending on how the enemy lined up, the Romans might greet them with arrows and artillery bolts or harass them with skirmishers and slingers. The latter would withdraw as the main infantry force of legionaries advanced.

Century in marching order

The legionaries approached the battlefield marching in disciplined ranks and files, probably led by their centurion and *signifer* – the junior officer who carried the century's standard.





Century in attack formation

The century has deployed in four ranks to attack, first launching a volley of javelins, then assuming closer order to smash into the enemy front line with a wall of shields.

